citing premise"; it helped that it came in a less-explored genre in OTT. "[As a child] there is a sense of innocence and one is vulnerable to the darker world, so, instinctively, you root for them," she explains. "But when the child is evil, that just comes as a shock." That *Adhura*'s lead actor, the nine-year-old 'Potterhead' Shrenik Arora, has superpowers that are used to terrify adults, is more icing on that wicked cake.

Aparna Purohit, head of originals at Amazon Prime Video, says there's still some "white space" when it comes to presenting stories centred around young adults. By backing a show like *Adhura*, Purohit wanted to make a case for how "critical" childhood years are and the role they play in shaping adults. "Unfortunately, we don't see much content that showcases a nuanced perspective of their lives, their trials and tribulations and their unique perspective of life," she says. "Most of the time, the children happen to be incidental to the stories they feature in." Thus, in the programming slate Purohit and her team curate, it's ensured that kids get well-etched characters and their presence adds value to the story. This couldn't be more evident than in season two of *The Family Man* (2019—), in which Srikant Tiwari's daughter, Dhriti (Ashlesha Thakur), played a major role in driving the plot.

A broader reason driving this wave of shows catering to the youth is simply the fact that India is growing young. In 2017, TVF, which appeared on the scene as a much-needed clutter-breaker, began making shows that met the needs of what Shreyansh Pandey, the head of TVF Originals, calls the "Torrent generation", who turned to the West for their entertainment fix. "There was a huge timespan wherein whatever was being telecast on TV wasn't exciting this generation," says Pandey.

Thus, it's perhaps to resonate better with the youth that filmmakers today are making sure that their shows don't trivialise the issues the demographic faces or patronise them as 'kids' who don't know any better. If *Adhura* looks at how childhood trauma can define one's whole life, *School of Lies* explores the sense of curiosity kids harbour and highlights how



The Family Man (season 2 , 2021)

IN THE PIPELINE



▲ COLLEGE ROMANCE
SonyLIV

The popular TVF show enters its fourth season with Gagan Arora, Apoorva Arora, Manjot Singh, Keshav Sadhna, Nupur Nagpal and Shreya Mehta entering the final year of college. Expect movie nights, trips, job woes and farewells

▼ THE ARCHIES
Netflix

Directed by Zoya Akhtar, it was the only Indian title to be featured at the recent TUDUM showcase in Brazil. It marks the debuts of Agastya Nanda, Suhana Khan, Khushi Kapoor, Aditi Saigal a.k.a. Dot, Vedang Raina, Yuvraj Menda and Mihir Ahuja





"THERE WAS A HUGE TIMESPAN [IN THE RECENT PAST] WHEREIN WHATEVER WAS BEING TELECAST ON TV WASN'T EXCITING THIS GENERATION. THE IDEA WAS TO RESONATE WITH THAT AUDIENCE"

SHREYANSH PANDEY, ***Head, TVF Originals***